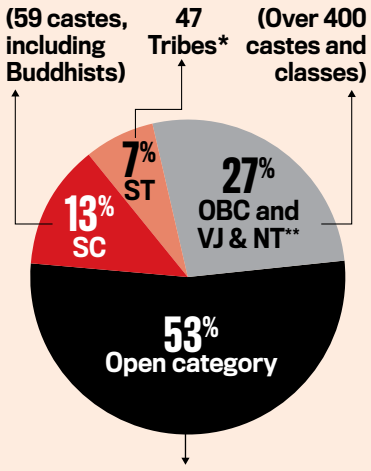
government had just about managed to secure a temporary reprieve on this front. On November 2, with an assurance of a suitable policy step by December 24, Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil had finally been persuaded to break his second fast-unto-death. But not before announcing a state-wide tour and goading community members to undertake a relay hunger strike to keep up the pressure. Jarange-Patil wants the Marathas, seen as forward caste because of their past association with kingship, to be clubbed with the Kunbis (with whom they share social origins) so that they can be eligible for OBC quotas. More nuanced voices say the problem of agrarian communities like the Marathas goes much beyond the reservation demand. Unprofitable farming and unaffordable higher education have together dealt a deadly double blow, with prosperity attritioned in the original vocation and denied in the private sector. Hence the scramble for government jobs, they argue.

THE MAHARASHTRA RESERVATION PIE



Some 100 castes, including Brahmins, Marathas, Saraswats, Rajputs, Kayasthas, Jains, elite castes among Muslims, Sikhs, Christians, Lingayat castes

**including 3 primitive tribal groups, Katkari, Warli, Gond; **VJ & NT: Vimukta Jati and nomadic tribes*

The demand has come in for stiff opposition from the Kunbis and the larger OBC cohort, who point to how the dominant Marathas control both the state's politics and the political economy. Groups like the Dhangars (shepherds), who are part of the nomadic tribe category, a sub-category of the OBCs in Maharashtra, are making parallel demands—they want to be included in the Scheduled Tribes category. Some Hindu Dalit leaders also want a sub-quota within the Scheduled Castes category.

The Justice G. Rohini-led commission, set up in 2017 to look at the sub-categorisation of Other Backward Classes (OBCs), submitted its report in July—after 13 extensions to its tenure reflected the Centre's own fluctuating approach. The commission examined the disparities in reservation benefits and how dominant groups among OBCs may have cornered the lion's share. But getting a precise fix on that is impossible without accurately measuring caste numbers. The last caste census took place in British India in 1931 and the present postulations are extrapolations of those numbers.

A CASTE CENSUS COULD DISRUPT EQUATIONS BY TURNING LONG-HELD NOTIONS OF COMMUNITY NUMBERS ON THEIR HEAD

An empirical survey of castes has the potential to disrupt social and political equations in Maharashtra. For instance, the Marathas dominate the social and political sectors based on the notion that the community forms 31.5 per cent of the population. However, this figure may include the Kunbis, who have massive numbers in Konkan and Vidarbha. More realistic estimates suggest the Marathas may be just around 12-16 per cent. The OBCs are estimated to be around 52.1 per cent. Largely leaving aside the 8.4 per cent non-Hindus within them, the OBCs formed the bedrock of support for the undivided Shiv Sena and the BJP, while the Marathas are regarded as the core constituency of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), which is now divided into factions led by Ajit and his uncle Sharad Pawar.

After the Maratha protests, OBC groups have become more vocal—they say a caste survey will disrupt the Maratha-centric order in the state. Babanrao Taywade of the Rashtriya OBC Mahasangh says, "OBCs could number around 60 per cent, not 52 per cent." He bases his calculations on the Mandal Commission report of 1980, which had identified 270 backward classes in Maharashtra, a number that has risen to around 400 now. Some sections like the denotified and nomadic tribes, outside the mainstream of prosperity, have the higher rates of fertility typical of immiserated groups. He sees the path ahead as logical: a caste census, a demand for removal of the 50 per cent cap on reservations, and higher quota allocations for the OBCs.

The issue has been gestating for two years. In March 2021, the Supreme Court struck down the state's 27 per cent political quota for OBCs in local bodies due to lack of empirical data about their backwardness. Later that year, the Maharashtra State Commission for Backward Classes (MSCBC) submitted a Rs 435 crore proposal for a caste census. However, the erstwhile Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi regime kept it pending, citing the Covid pandemic and the huge expenses involved. In March 2022, the state government finally set up a dedicated commission under former chief secretary J.K. Banthia to collect data on the